Mahabharata. Later Buddhist texts, such as the *Mahavastu*, refer to Gandhara and Kamboja—approximating today's Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa and parts of Afghanistan—as among the *mahajanapadas* or 'great states' of India. Other early Buddhist scriptures recount maritime voyages, coinciding with evidence of early trade with both West and Southeast Asia. [5]

Taken together, the Vedic texts, Puranas, and Buddhist and Jain literature offer a rich illustration of statecraft in the period from roughly the ninth to the third centuries BCE. The *mahajanapadas* included both *rajyas* (kingdoms) and *ganas* (oligarchies or republics in which power was shared). This period saw the rise of cities like Kashi and Mathura as political centres, Ujjain as a trading hub between the Gangetic plain and the Arabian Sea, and to the north-west the celebrated locus of learning Taxila, described in later Roman and Chinese sources. Magadha—around modern-day Bihar—eventually rose to be the most powerful state in north-central India between the sixth and fourth centuries BCE, first under Bimbisara and his successors and later under the Nandas. Subsequent accounts by foreigners describe reports of the Nandas ruling over massive, powerful armies.

The north-western Indian regions, or at least parts of them, were conquered by Persia in the sixth century. Persian records at Persepolis and Hamadan mention Gandhara and Hidus (possibly referring to Hindus of the Indus Valley) as subjects and tributaries. For Persia's leaders, parts of India remained important sources of mercenaries and highly sought-after war elephants during the fifth and fourth centuries BCE. Despite some cultural legacies, such as the introduction of the Kharoshti script, Persian influence appears to have waned in north-western India by the time of Alexander of Macedon's invasion of Punjab in 327–26 BCE. [6]

After spending a considerable period subjugating Central Asia and Afghanistan, Alexander decided to move beyond traditional Persian lands and invade India, a land associated in Greek minds with mystery and wonder—the edge of the known world. His armies moved through the Khyber and Swat to Taxila, laying siege to several cities and Alexander